realizing that he had room for only one newcomer, said that he would give the opening to the man who practiced the oldest profession. One stepped forward and said, “I guess that’s me, because I’m a surgeon; we all know the Lord made the earth in six days and then created man, and from Adam’s rib he created woman—and that took surgery.” But before he could move forward, the second man stepped up and said, “Wait just a minute, I’m an engineer; in those six days before the creation of man, everything was chaos and the Lord had to work six days and six nights to eliminate the chaos; that took engineering.” Before Saint Peter could respond, the third man stepped forward and said, “Well, I’m an economist, and where do you think they got all that chaos?”

Thomas Jefferson once said about lawyers: “On every question the lawyers are about equally divided, and were we to act but in cases where no contrary opinion of a lawyer can be had, we should never act.” I think you could say the same thing about economists.

One thing was absolutely clear: To reduce the deficit, we’d have to render fat which had worked its way into the federal budget over decades of mismanagement and ill-guided giveaway programs and persuade Congress to stop adding fat to the budget every year. But, just as it became evident that we needed more cuts, the coalition that had come together to pass the twenty-five-percent, three-year tax cut and the Gramm-Latta budget reductions began to disintegrate.

The 1982 congressional elections were less than a year away. Many Democrats who had stuck their necks out and supported these bills returned to the party fold; Tip O’Neill and other Democratic leaders had brought them into line with warnings that they’d lose important committee assignments as well as the party’s financial help during the election.